

Respect Yourself and Others: Pat in Her Own Words

Coach Pat Summitt

My mom taught me a lot about respect. She only went through the ninth grade ... loving, caring, respectful of everyone. The only person in my life I've never heard anyone say a bad word about was my mom. But she taught me about respect.

If you want to have a great team, everyone on your team has to feel important. Do they not? My secretary has been with me (for) 23 years. Now that's a long time to be with anyone. My husband hasn't even lived with me that long.

But Katie is the person that I talk to every morning when I get up. And when I started out working with Katie, I didn't know Katie. I might call her and say, 'Katie, look. Tell me the four things I have to do this morning.' I quickly learned to say, 'Katie' ... on a Monday morning ... 'how was your weekend? How are you doing? How's your family doing?' And start to develop (the) relationship.

My student managers ... when you do what we do, we just recruit a lot of people to come help us. And our student managers are really, really key. We got ready this year to go to the Final Four. I turned in my list of who on our staff would be going to the Final Four.

And Joan Cronan, our AD (athletic director), called me up and she said, 'Pat, is it really necessary to take all eight student managers to the Final Four?' And I said, 'How many of your administrators are going?' She said, 'It'll be fine if you take all eight of your student managers.' You know, they're the people behind the scenes. They're not the up-front people.

But everyone in your organization has to feel that they will bring something to the table and something to the team to allow you to be successful.